



Program for
Inclusion and
Neurodiversity
Education

PINE Case Study

The Kids ‘Can’t Wait’: An Urgent but Practical Approach to Inclusion in Greenwich

Carefully tailored plans and multiple paths to engagement are helping time-strapped Greenwich Public Schools educators make the most of PINE.

Sometimes, what looks like inclusion is anything but.

It’s a fact that worried Dr. Stacey Heiligenthaler and her team at Greenwich Public Schools. Heiligenthaler, who joined the district as its Chief Officer of Special Education and Student Supports in 2021, says GPS did a great job moving more special education students out of self-contained classrooms and into general education ones. But once they were there, they often sat on the side, interacting far more with paraprofessionals — aides assigned to help them, also known as “paras” — than with the classroom teacher or their peers.

A 2021 audit of the district by an outside consulting group criticized GPS as having classes “that are inclusionary in name only.” Consultants noted “lingering” achievement gaps between the district’s students with disabilities and nondisabled peers, while collaborative classrooms were not organized in ways to meet the needs of students with IEPs.

Key to addressing the audit’s critiques, Heiligenthaler says, would be providing training and support to both general education teachers and paras so that they could establish truly inclusive classroom environments. As is often the case, however, there were concerns over how teachers could fit more training into their busy schedules.

The district’s demographics could also prove a complicating factor. Greenwich has a reputation as a bastion of wealth, and many of the school district’s students do come from affluent families. But the district is also home to three Title 1 schools with low-income students as well as a sizeable population of English language learners from immigrant or expatriate families. These circumstances, as well as other variables like

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school leadership and school size, meant that each Greenwich school differed from the others in significant ways. No one-size-fits-all solution could suffice.

Such challenges notwithstanding, GPS forged ahead with a new plan.

“We couldn’t sit there and say, ‘We won’t give you skills to teach kids how to read or how to be better teachers for our neurodiverse kids,’” Heiligenthaler says. “They need it now. They can’t wait.”

Working With PINE

GPS partnered with the Program for Inclusion and Neurodiversity Education (PINE) on an initiative to empower teachers, paraprofessionals and other staff with inclusive strategies and practices.

The initiative focused on the district’s 11 elementary schools. It began with an accelerator program in which PINE consultants guided leaders at every school through four one-hour sessions. In these sessions, leaders conducted Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats (SWOT) analysis. Then, with PINE’s help, leaders carefully devised plans tailored to their respective schools.

“The goal is to give everyone a clear plan for the year so that people aren’t floundering,” explains Samara Sweig, Vice President of Business Strategy and Operations at PINE. “People figure out what they need to know, like what their needs are, and how they’re going to tackle them.”

Since the schools’ needs varied widely, so did their respective plans. Some centered on having paraprofessionals engage with PINE’s online learning platform, which features learning modules on understanding autism and executive functioning, micro-courses on subjects such as using visual supports and ableism in the classroom, discussion guides for further professional development and insights from neurodivergent experts. Other plans

The Power of Internal Champions

How do you convince hundreds of teachers and staff, all with competing demands on their time, to undertake a brand new, comprehensive training program? Designating strong internal champions for the program can make the difference between widespread adoption and willful disengagement.

“If I’m going to support a teacher, I might say, ‘I saw this resource in the PINE online library — perhaps we can use this support that particular situation.’ Or, if a student is really struggling and their team has tried A through Z solutions, I might suggest that they hop on PINE office hours and see if an outside perspective can help,” explains GPS Inclusion Specialist Rachel Rubin, one of the district’s PINE champions. *“It’s about making sure that people remember we have all these tools and resources.”*

Other PINE champions in the district include members of



encouraged use of the platform by Special Area Teachers and non-instructional staff. Still, others focused largely on PINE's "office hours" — live, virtual meetings with PINE consultants. During these meetings, groups of educators came together to talk with the consultants about specific student challenges and how to address them.

"We tried to introduce it in multiple ways," Heiligenthaler says. "We have our general professional development, but we're also working one kid at a time, one team at a time."

The rollout of the initiative hit a hurdle when a rumor circulated that PINE's online learning modules were mandatory for teachers, leading to confusion. In response, Heiligenthaler and her team emphasized that participation was voluntary and designed to help, not burden, staff. (See sidebar.) As teachers and educators began accessing PINE resources on their own terms, the partnership got back on track.

GPS's professional learning communities. These groups largely consist of assistant principals who regularly visit each other's schools to observe what practices are working well in various classrooms, including PINE strategies, and then take that information back to the educators at their schools.

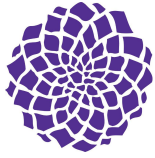
"There is a lot of communication with our staff that PINE is a support and not just another initiative or to-do," Heiligenthaler says. "And when teachers see that it helps them, that's a conversation they have with their colleagues."

Step by Step Toward Success

Just three months into their partnership with PINE, GPS officials say they're seeing a noticeable shift in mindsets and approaches among teachers and staff. For instance, many are embracing one of PINE's foundational concepts — that educators should leverage students' strengths in helping them learn, rather than focus only on their weaknesses.

"We had a speech language pathologist say that it's totally changed the way she approaches writing goals and designing services. She's no longer looking at it from a deficit mindset," Heiligenthaler says. "That's what we want."

Paraprofessionals have enthusiastically embraced PINE's coursework and are applying what they're learning in classrooms, whether it's deescalating a situation when a student is misbehaving or giving more breaks so that the student is prepared to actively participate in a lesson or class activity. "They have the knowledge that a student is reacting in a certain way because of their neurodiversity and trying new ways to support them," GPS Inclusion Specialist Rachel Rubin says. "We're starting to see those little differences in how they work with students."



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And teachers, paras and other staff are increasingly turning to PINE office hours for help. Between November 2022 and March 2023, GPS logged over 40 hours talking with PINE consultants through virtual meetings.

“They’re getting helpful information in real time,” Heiligenthaler says.

The benefits of the GPS-PINE partnership extend beyond the district’s special education program. Officials say that teachers and staff are learning that PINE strategies can be applied widely, across student populations, helping both general education students and students with IEPs. And it provides general education students with an understanding of neurodiversity — something that they can carry with them into adulthood.

“It gives them the language to explain that all our bodies and brains just work differently, so student A might need one thing to learn best and student B might need something else,” Heiligenthaler says. “It empowers school staff to have those conversations with kids, who will be the next generation of adults that we want celebrating neurodiversity.”